

# Faking it!

## I'M TORN BETWEEN MY HATE FOR FAKE

**NEWS** and detesting limitations on freedom of speech and expression. In past columns I have talked about both, but the internet being what it is, has brought them together on opposite sides. What we call fake news started getting popular on the internet with satire sites, places like 4Chan and on forums as jokes. The problem really took off when people started believing the jokes to be actual news, because the 'fake news' was getting less and less ridiculous.

While it's easy to tell that Google's joke about opening a datacenter on Mars called Ziggy Stardust is just another April Fools prank, some of the other stuff that makes the rounds (especially as memes) is just terrible. From trying to incite violence, making up fake stories about something local, targeting politicians and people in the public eye, and even spreading lies about our neighbours... the world's gone a tad crazy!

If the last two decades showed us all the good side of connecting the people of the world to one another, the past few years has shown us the hideous underbelly of the internet. However, there are two sides to every coin. While it's easy to make up laws and requirements for service providers to curb fake news, we have to first of all decide on a method to identify fake news. Because we live in a country where the rule of power is almost absolute, it's important to admit that while we hate fake news, we should hate the idea of giving rich and powerful people the ability to silence all criticism of them even more.

As we've seen in the last few years from some wacky foreign leaders, it's far too easy to label every negative news about someone fake, and believe only the positive... or vice versa, if you happen to dislike the person.

Recently Facebook has been on the warpath trying to convince us that it will stamp out fake news on its platform. WhatsApp has limited the amount of times things can be forwarded, and no doubt others will follow suit. I'd like to believe most service providers want to do this because they have a conscience and do not want people to die based on rumours – as an estimated 31 people have been killed because of a silly WhatsApp forward. No it wasn't religious, political, targeting someone famous, or trying to

pitch castes against one another... it was a video from Pakistan showing men on a motorcycle kidnapping a child, which was rebranded as an Indian video, and claimed that gangs of "outsiders" were looking for children to kidnap in order to harvest their organs for ailing rich kids that needed them. This made xenophobia rise to a fever pitch, with all those who looked like outsiders from a region being looked at suspiciously, and in some cases, lynched.

While the conscience of service providers has been pricked, there's also self-preservation at stake. No service provider wants to be seen as doing nothing to combat fake news. It's not just public perception that matters, but also a very real fear of being banned from use in the country that is the most promising market in the world.

Although I understand the goal, which is to reign in fake news from spreading like wildfire, I'm skeptical about us solving this as a pure technology problem. It's not one. Technology is pretty much always just a passive tool that can be used for good and evil. You can use a hammer to build a house for a homeless person, or bludgeon him to death, and holding the hammer accountable for the latter is just a tad silly. Of course service providers will do something about it, because they want their business to flourish, but just leaving it at that is a huge mistake.

Instead of educating the masses we're censoring what they see and read, which may work in the short run, but will leave them just as vulnerable when the next big technology innovation comes along and infiltrates their lives. Technology generations are far, far quicker than human lifespans, and while all of the people on WhatsApp now will still very much be using technology five years, a decade, two decades from now, I seriously doubt that it's WhatsApp that they will be using.

The current crackdown is probably a necessary knee-jerk reaction, but the challenge is to maintain our liberty and individual rights at the same time. What we really need is a way to educate people about fake news and the internet, and to understand what reliable sources are. Do you have any suggestions for how we could do that? 



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